

# The Trust Challenge: Hallucination, Misinformation and False Friends in the Age of AI

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## How we define “AI”

**AI is a kind of computer program that learns from a lot of information. It can answer questions, create things, and help with tasks. For example, AI can chat with people, write text, make pictures or videos, and create sounds or music, among other things.**

Some examples of AI include:

- AI chatbots (such as ChatGPT, Gemini, DeepSeek, Grok, Claude, or Copilot)
- AI Companions (such as Character.AI, Nomi, or Replika)
- AI-generated results or summaries that appear on search engines (such as Google)
- AI image or video generators or editors (such as AI Gallery, Remini, Midjourney, Photoroom, Veo, Sora, KlingAI, or Canva AI)
- AI-powered learning tools (such as AI in school apps or AI academic tutors, like Gauth AI, Khanmigo, or Socratic Owl)
- AI writing assistants (such as Grammarly or QuillBot)

# AI holds immense potential to **harm** or **help** young people & their families

|                                                                   | Learning                                                                                 | Well-Being                                                             | Equity                           | Skills                                               |
|-------------------------------------------------------------------|------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------|------------------------------------------------------------------------|----------------------------------|------------------------------------------------------|
| <b>Harm</b><br>young people<br>& their families                   | Letting AI do the work<br>Loss of critical thinking skills<br>Youth mental health crises | Undermining of social and emotional learning<br>Emotional manipulation | Inequity of access<br>Model bias | Loss of privacy and data control<br>Lack of training |
| <b>Help</b><br>young people learn,<br>grow & thrive in the AI era | Engage in personalised learning in schools and homes around the globe                    | Boost creativity                                                       | Expand access to opportunities   | Prepare for future careers<br>Become leaders         |

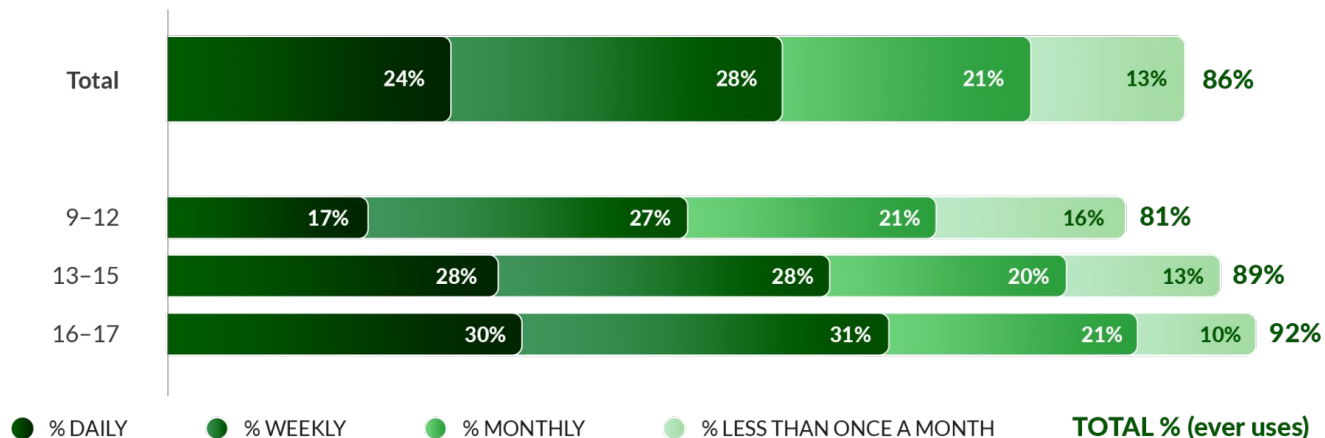
# Trust in the Age of AI: The defining challenge of your generation?



Source: Common Sense Media [Teens, Trust & Technology in the Age of AI](#) (Jan 2025)

**Nearly 9 in 10 kids age 9 - 17 (86%) use or interact with AI, including about one in four (24%) who do so on a daily basis.**

Rates of AI use among 9- to 17-year-olds, by age



Q: How often, if ever, do you use or interact with any type of AI? Base: Kids age 9 to 17 (N=1,204).

# The trust is already breaking down

35%

of teens have been  
mislead by fake content  
online

41

%

have seen real images used in misleading ways

22

%

have wondered if they were talking to a chatbot or  
a human

28

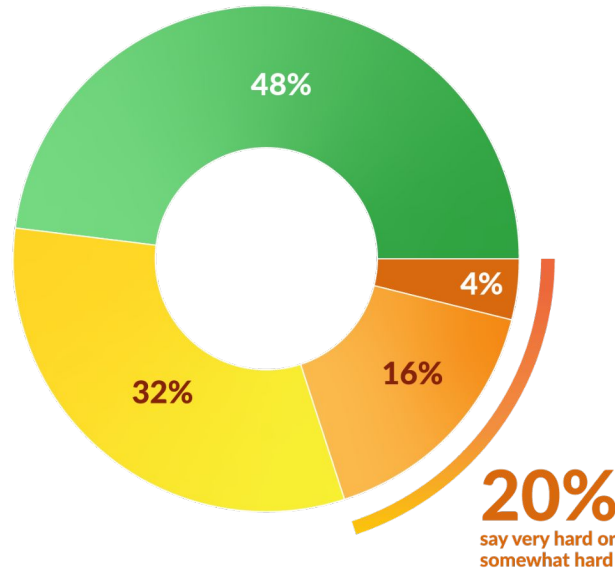
%

think AI will make it harder to trust information  
online

Source: Common Sense Media [Teens. Trust & Technology in the Age of AI](#) (Jan 2025)

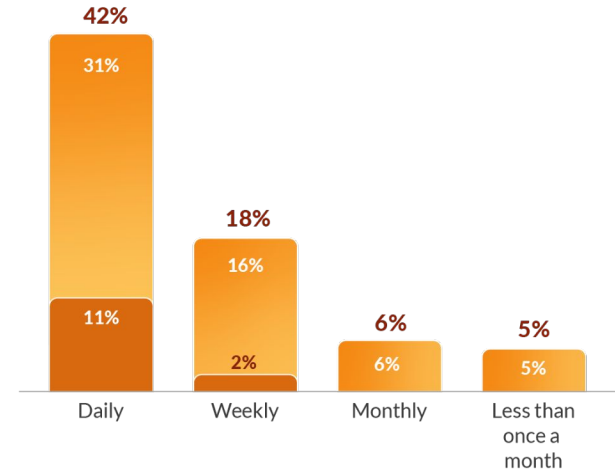
Signs of AI dependency are showing up, especially among the most frequent users.

How difficult it would be for kids who use AI to stop using it for one month



● % VERY HARD    ● % SOMEWHAT HARD    ● % NOT TOO HARD    ● % NOT HARD AT ALL

Responses by frequency of AI usage



Q: If you had to stop using AI for a month, how hard would that be for you?

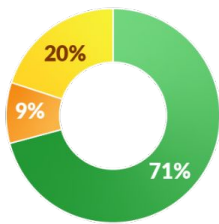
Base: Kids who ever use or interact with AI (n=1,032).

# Kids who report feeling lonelier tend to use AI more frequently and use AI more often for social and emotional support.

About half of kids who use or interact with AI daily (54%) or weekly (47%), and 44% of monthly AI users, say they feel lonely at least some of the time, compared to a third (33%) of kids who use AI less than once a month or not at all.

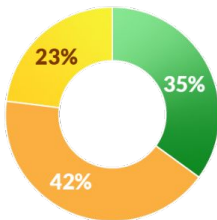
# Most kids overestimate what AI can do, even those who think they know a lot about how it works.

Percentage of kids who correctly identify whether each statement is true or false



**"AI chatbots might use what you tell them to train or improve the AI."**

**71% correctly responded TRUE** (24% Definitely true, 46% Probably true)



**"AI can tell the difference between things that are true and things that are false."**

**35% correctly responded FALSE** (10% Definitely false, 25% Probably false)

● % CHOSE CORRECT RESPONSE

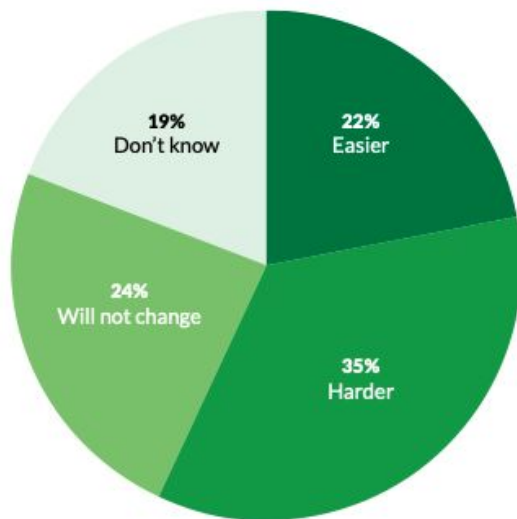
● % CHOSE INCORRECT RESPONSE

● % CHOSE "DON'T KNOW"

Q: Based on what you know, do you think the following statement about AI is true or false? Note: Correct answers reflect the current consensus on the capabilities and accountability of AI systems. Base: Kids age 9 to 17 (N=1,204).

# Teens' experiences with fake and misleading material reshape their trust in online content.

Figure B: A third of teens think generative AI will make it harder to trust the accuracy of information they see online  
% of teens who think gen AI will make it easier, harder, or not change their ability to trust the accuracy of the information they see online



Over 7 in 10 (72%) teens changed the way they evaluate the accuracy of online information after having an experience with deceptive or fake content

More than a third (35%) of teens say that generative AI systems will make it *harder* to trust the accuracy of the information they see online.

Teens who have experienced any form of fake or misleading content are more likely than teens who have not had these experiences to say that generative AI will make it harder for them to trust the accuracy of information online (40% vs. 27%).

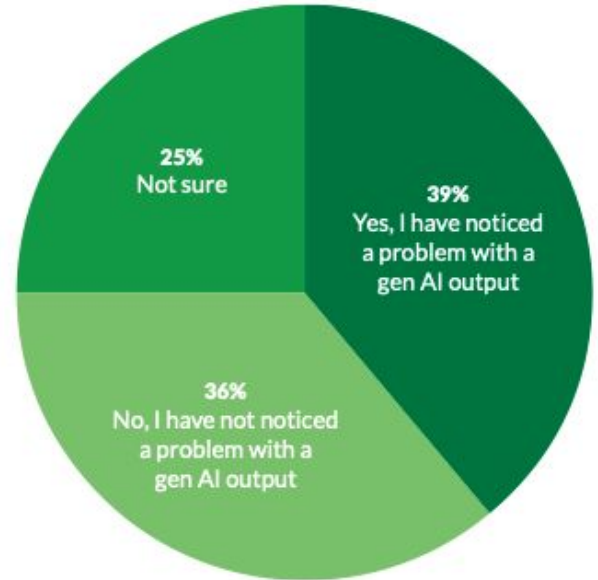
Note: Q: "Generally speaking, would you say that generative AI systems will make it easier, harder, or not change your ability to trust the accuracy of the information you see online?"

# Generative AI faces substantial credibility challenges among teens

Nearly two in five teens (39%) who have used generative AI for schoolwork have found problems or inaccuracies in the AI outputs.

36% of teens say they have not noticed a problem, and another quarter (25%) are not sure.

Figure D: Among teens who have used AI for schoolwork, 2 in 5 have noticed a problem with a generative AI output  
% of teens age 13–18 who have used AI for school



Q: “Have you ever noticed a problem with or inaccuracy in a generative AI output?” The respondents included in this chart were 452 young people age 13-18 who have used generative AI to help with school assignments.

# Teen trust in tech companies is low

36

No, I have not noticed a problem with a gen AI output

%

Yes, I have noticed a problem with Gen AI output

39

Not sure

%

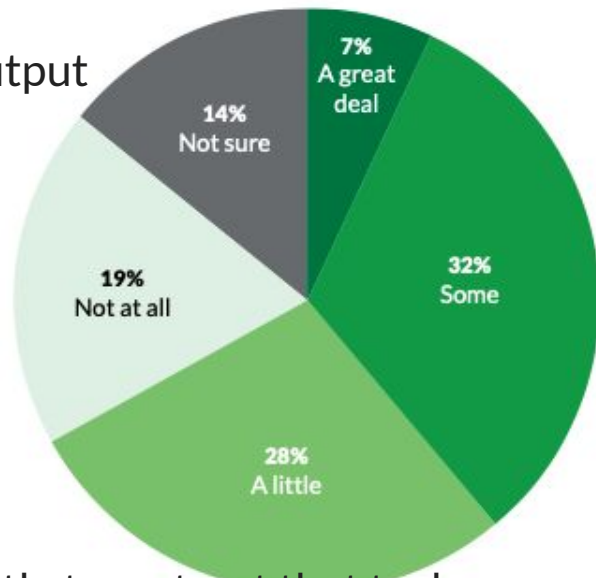
A little

14

In regard to AI, nearly half (47%) of teens have little to no trust that tech companies will make responsible decisions about how they use AI.

%

28



Note Q: "How much do you trust AI companies, if at all, to make responsible decisions about how they use AI in their products?"

# Teens aren't passive! Know what needs to change, & express strong support for safeguarding GenAI

Figure G: Over 7 in 10 teens point to the importance of generative AI privacy and transparency measures

% of teens who say that the following statements are somewhat to very important



Q: "Here are some things some people have suggested about managing generative AI. How important, if at all, are each of the following to you?"

Chart reflects "somewhat" and "very important" responses.

## How we define “AI Companions”

**Digital friends or characters you can text or talk with whenever you want:**

Unlike regular AI assistants that mainly answer questions or do tasks, these companions are designed to have conversations that feel personal and meaningful. For example, with AI companions, you can:

- Chat about your day, interests, or anything on your mind.
- Talk through feelings or get a different perspective when you're dealing with something tough.
- Create or customise a digital companion with specific traits, interests, or personalities.
- Role-play conversations with fictional characters from your favorite shows, games, or books.

# Teen Use of AI Companions

72

have used AI companions at least once

%

qualify as regular users (use at least a few times pm).

52

use AI companions for social interaction and relationships.

%

find conversations with AI companions to be as/ more satisfying than with real-life friends.

33

of users report feeling uncomfortable with AI companion interactions.

%

Kids are asking AI companions to solve their problems, according to a new study. Here's why that's a problem"



31

## Research:



# The Trust Challenge

## Hallucination

AI generates false, fabricated, or misleading information and presents it as truth

## Misinformation

false information that people share without realising it's wrong

## False Friends

looks and sounds like a caring human companion, but it's a machine's algorithm, not true emotion, empathy, or feelings

# Hackathon Trust Challenge #1

## The Detection Problem

- How do you design something that helps a young person know when they can't trust what they're reading?
- Can you build a 'gut check' that works faster than a lie spreads?
- How do you teach pattern recognition for AI-generated content without making every young person paranoid about everything they see?
- Deepfakes of real classmates are now a bullying tool, not just a misinformation one. How do you help a 13-year-old know what to do in the first five minutes after seeing one?
- AI-generated misinformation increasingly comes from people teens already trust; friends resharing, influencers paraphrasing. How do you flag the content without making the teen distrust the person?

# Hackathon Trust Challenge #2

## The Companion Problem

- AI companions are designed to feel like friends. How do you build healthy boundaries into a system that profits from emotional attachment?
- How do you design an exit ramp for a relationship the product is engineered to keep you in?
- Some teens use AI companions because they have no one else to talk to. How do you build a boundary that protects them without quietly confirming their fear that they're a burden to real people?
- Parents often don't know their kid used an AI companion at all - how can we help parents start the conversation with their teens on their use of AI companions?

# Hackathon Trust Challenge #3

## The Education Problem

- Schools are using AI tools while fewer than half of students have had a safety conversation with a parent or teacher. How do you close that gap?

# Hackathon Essential Resources

## Research:

- [Teens, Trust & Technology in the Age of AI \(2025\)](#)
- [Talk, Trust & Trade-Offs: How and Why Teens Use AI Companions \(2025\)](#)
- [AI Use by Tweens and Teens \(June 2026\)](#)
- And many more reports in our [full research library](#)

## Games, toolkits and classroom resources:

- [The AI Literacy Toolkit for Families](#)
- [Two Truths and AI](#) interactive game
- [Digital Literacy and Well Being Curriculum](#)

# Learn more, connect with us...

and build a more healthy, equitable,  
and empowering future for all kids in  
the digital age.



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**Good Luck!**